# Accelerating Physics-Informed Learning via Power-Law Extreme Learning Machines

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**Abstract**

Iterative Physics-Informed Neural Networks (PINNs) suffer from high training latency and spectral bias. We propose a Power-Law Extreme Learning Machine (EM-ELM) that utilizes a heavy-tailed weight initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$) to create a multiscale physical basis. By replacing iterative backpropagation with a one-shot analytical projection, the EM-ELM achieves a measured $7.3\times$ wall-clock speedup over a single-layer PINN and $416\times$ over a four-layer deep PINN on the 1-D Poisson benchmark. Our statistical analysis across 20 independent seeds demonstrates that the Power-Law prior stabilizes the random projection, yielding an $80\%$ reduction in mean $L_2$ relative error compared to standard Gaussian initializations. A complementary classification experiment on MNIST and FashionMNIST confirms the generality of the approach.

*Keywords:* Physics-Informed Neural Networks, Extreme Learning Machines, Power-Law Initialization, Energy Minimization, Spectral Bias

## 1. Introduction

The emergence of Physics-Informed Neural Networks (PINNs) has redefined the landscape of computational science by integrating fundamental physical laws, expressed as partial differential equations (PDEs), directly into the deep learning objective function. Despite their transformative potential, traditional PINNs rely on iterative, gradient-based optimization—specifically Backpropagation (BP)—which presents significant computational bottlenecks. These models often suffer from spectral bias, where the network prioritizes learning low-frequency components of the solution while struggling to capture high-frequency or multiscale features. Furthermore, the non-convex nature of the PINN loss landscape frequently leads to slow convergence or entrapment in local minima, necessitating thousands of iterations and significant GPU resources to reach acceptable precision.

To address these limitations, we propose the Power-Law Extreme Learning Machine (EM-ELM), a paradigm shift from iterative training to one-shot analytical projection. Traditional Extreme Learning Machines (ELMs) offer an attractive alternative due to their randomized hidden

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layers and linear output weights, which can be solved via a single matrix inversion. However, standard ELMs typically employ Gaussian or Xavier initializations, which often fail to provide a sufficiently diverse basis for complex physical manifolds, resulting in poor approximation accuracy.

Our work introduces a Multiscale Power-Law Initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$) that transforms the ELM's random features into a robust physical basis. By utilizing heavy-tailed weight distributions, the EM-ELM generates a spectrum of neurons capable of capturing both global trends and sharp gradients simultaneously. This architectural choice effectively bypasses the spectral bias inherent in iterative methods. By formulating the training process as a Regularized Energy Minimization problem, we derive the output weights through a deterministic analytical solve. This approach provides a significant "speed-accuracy" advantage: on the 1-D Poisson benchmark our results demonstrate a measured $7.3\times$ speedup over a single-layer PINN and $416\times$ over a four-layer deep PINN, while maintaining competitive accuracy.

### *1.1. The Logic of Energy Minimization*

The core insight of the EM-ELM is geometric. Once the hidden-layer weights are fixed by the Power-Law prior, the network output becomes a *linear* function of the output weights $\beta$. Training therefore reduces to projecting the target physics onto a fixed, high-dimensional linear subspace—a convex quadratic problem whose global minimum is guaranteed by the normal equations. This contrasts with the "searching" behaviour of backpropagation, which navigates a non-convex loss landscape with no convergence guarantee.

### *1.2. Key Contributions*

- **Novel Initialization:** Introduction of a Power-Law stochastic prior ($\alpha = 2.0$) that resolves the frequency-coverage limitations of traditional random networks.
- **Analytical Efficiency:** Elimination of the backpropagation bottleneck through a one-shot Tikhonov-regularized projection.
- **Statistical Validation:** Demonstration of robustness through a 20-seed statistical analysis, proving an $80\%$ error reduction over standard Gaussian ELMs.
- **Performance Benchmarking:** A measured $7.3\times$ wall-clock speedup over a single-layer PINN and $416\times$ over a four-layer deep PINN on the 1-D Poisson benchmark, demonstrating suitability for real-time edge computing and digital twins.

### *1.3. Related Work*

The development of the Power-Law EM-ELM intersects three rapidly evolving domains: Physics-Informed Neural Networks (PINNs), Extreme Learning Machines (ELMs), and the emerging field of Neural Operators.

#### *1.3.1. Physics-Informed Neural Networks (PINNs)*

Since the landmark work of Raissi et al. [1], PINNs have become the standard for solving forward and inverse problems in PDEs. By embedding the PDE residual into the loss function, these models ensure that the learned solution adheres to physical laws. However, recent literature emphasizes that the backpropagation process in PINNs is prone to spectral bias [2, 3], where the network converges to low-frequency solutions while neglecting high-frequency details. Wang et al. [4] further demonstrated via neural tangent kernel analysis that PINNs exhibit spectral bias, with extremely slow convergence to high-frequency solution components. Our work addresses this by replacing iterative search with a multiscale analytical projection.

#### *1.3.2. Extreme Learning Machines (ELMs) and Random Projections*

The ELM architecture, pioneered by Huang et al. [5], offers a radical alternative to backpropagation by utilizing fixed, random hidden layers and analytically solving for output weights. Dong and Li [6] extended ELMs to PDE solving via local networks and domain decomposition, and Dwivedi and Srinivasan [7] independently introduced PIELM for direct ELM-based PDE solving; both demonstrate orders-of-magnitude improvements over PINN but rely on standard random initialization. While ELMs are known for their extreme training speed, they traditionally rely on Gaussian initializations that struggle to capture the complex manifolds of physical systems. The proposed EM-ELM bridges this gap by introducing Power-Law initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$), which provides the frequency diversity required for high-precision physics tasks.

#### *1.3.3. Randomized Numerical Linear Algebra and Neural Operators*

Our methodology also draws from Randomized Numerical Linear Algebra, where random sketches are used to approximate high-dimensional matrices. In the context of "AI for Science," our approach can be viewed as a stochastic variant of Fourier Neural Operators (FNO) [8] or DeepONet. Unlike FNOs, which require extensive training on large datasets to learn operators, the EM-ELM creates a "ready-made" operator basis through its multiscale weights, enabling a solve that is both faster and more computationally efficient than existing operators.

## 2. Methods

### *2.1. Stochastic Feature Mapping with Power-Law Priors*

Standard neural networks typically utilize Gaussian or Xavier initialization, which are localized in the weight space. In contrast, our proposed EM-ELM employs a Power-Law distribution for the hidden layer weights $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times h}$, defined by the probability density function:

$$P(w) \propto |w|^{-\alpha}$$

For our implementation, we set $\alpha = 2.0$. This specific value is significant because it represents a "critical state" in statistical mechanics, creating a multiscale basis. Unlike Gaussian weights that focus on a single frequency band, the heavy tails of the Power-Law distribution generate neurons that capture both high-frequency sharp gradients and low-frequency global structures.

For the PDE solver, we employ the sinusoidal activation $\phi(x) = \sin(x)$, whose smooth higher-order derivatives are essential for computing the differential equation residuals. For classification

tasks, we use the standard sigmoid activation $\sigma(x) = 1/(1 + e^{-x})$. The iterative PINN baseline uses the hyperbolic tangent activation.

### *2.2. The Energy Functional and Analytical Projection*

Rather than iteratively minimizing a loss function via backpropagation, we treat the hidden states $H = \sigma(XW + b)$ as a fixed physical basis. The goal is to find output weights $\beta$ that satisfy the physics of the system. This is achieved by minimizing the Regularized Energy Functional $J(\beta)$:

$$J(\beta) = \min_{\beta} \|H\beta - y\|_2^2 + \lambda\|\beta\|_2^2$$

where $\lambda$ is the Tikhonov regularization parameter [9]. The stationary point of this functional ($\nabla_\beta J = 0$) provides a global minimum through the One-Shot Ridge Solve:

$$\beta = (H^T H + \lambda I)^{-1} H^T y$$

For high-dimensional physics data, we optimize this solve using Cholesky Decomposition ($LL^T = H^T H + \lambda I$), which reduces computational complexity from $O(n^3)$ to $O(\frac{1}{3}n^3)$, enabling the $7.3\times$ speedup observed in our results. In our experiments, the ELM uses $h = 4096$ hidden neurons; this generous over-parameterisation ensures the random basis is rich enough to span the solution manifold without iterative refinement. The regularisation $\lambda = 10^{-6}$ was selected via a coarse logarithmic sweep ($10^{-8}$–$10^{-2}$) to balance numerical conditioning with approximation fidelity. The PINN baseline uses a single hidden layer of 128 neurons (matching the shallow-network comparison) trained with 400 iterations of the Adam optimiser (lr $= 5 \times 10^{-3}$).

### *2.3. Resolving Spectral Bias in PDEs*

A primary failure mode for standard PINNs is spectral bias, where gradient descent learns low-frequency components significantly faster than high-frequency ones, leading to long training times for complex solutions.

The EM-ELM bypasses this iterative bottleneck:

- **Basis Diversity:** The Power-Law initialization provides the "frequency diversity" needed to span the solution space without training.
- **Analytical Certainty:** By solving the global energy minimum in one step, we avoid the non-convex optimization traps that caused the PINN to take 2.074 s compared to the ELM's 0.282 s.

## 3. Theoretical Complexity Analysis and Derivation

To rigorously justify the empirical $416\times$ speedup observed in our results, we perform a formal computational complexity analysis comparing the proposed EM-ELM with the standard PINN framework.

Table 1: Comparison of Computational Paradigms: PINN vs. Traditional ELM vs. Proposed EM-ELM.

| **Feature** | **PINN (Iterative)** | **Traditional ELM** | **Proposed EM-ELM** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Optimization Strategy | Local Gradient Search | Analytical Projection | **Global Analytical Projection** |
| Initialization Prior | Gaussian/Xavier | Gaussian (Scale-limited) | **Power-Law (Multiscale)** |
| Convergence Type | Stochastic/Iterative | Deterministic/One-shot | **Deterministic/One-shot** |
| Spectral Coverage | Sequential (Slow) | Poor (Localized) | **Immediate (Diverse)** |
| Computational Graph | Required (Auto-Diff) | Not Required | **Not Required** |
| Training Complexity | $\mathcal{O}(I \cdot N \cdot h \cdot d)$ | $\mathcal{O}(N \cdot h^2 + h^3)$ | $\mathcal{O}(N \cdot h^2 + h^3)$ |

$I$: Iterations, $N$: Training points, $h$: Hidden units, $d$: Input dimensions.

### *3.1. Complexity of the Iterative PINN*

The computational cost of a PINN is dominated by the backpropagation algorithm applied over $I$ iterations. For a network with $L$ layers and a constant hidden dimension $h$, the cost per iteration is determined by the forward and backward passes:

- **Forward/Backward Pass:** $O(N \cdot L \cdot h^2)$, where $N$ is the number of collocation points.
- **Automatic Differentiation (AD):** Computing the PDE residual (e.g., $u_{xx}$) requires multiple passes through the computational graph, effectively multiplying the base cost by a factor $k$ proportional to the order of the derivative.

The total complexity for a PINN to reach convergence is:

$$T_{\text{PINN}} \approx O(I \cdot k \cdot N \cdot L \cdot h^2)$$

Given that $I$ often exceeds $10^3$ to $10^4$ for non-linear PDEs, the cumulative cost becomes prohibitive as $N$ scales.

### *3.2. Complexity of the Proposed EM-ELM*

The EM-ELM bypasses the iterative loop entirely. Its complexity is the sum of three distinct phases:

- **Feature Mapping** ($H = \sigma(XW + b)$): A single matrix multiplication and activation. Cost: $O(N \cdot h)$.
- **Covariance Construction** ($H^T H$): Forming the normal equations. Cost: $O(N \cdot h^2)$.
- **Analytical Solve** (Cholesky/Ridge): Solving the linear system $(H^T H + \lambda I)\beta = H^T y$. Cost: $O(h^3)$.

The total complexity for EM-ELM is:

$$T_{\text{EM-ELM}} \approx O(N \cdot h^2 + h^3)$$

### 3.3. Comparative Scaling and Speedup Derivation

We define the Theoretical Speedup Factor ($\mathcal{S}$) as the ratio of their respective complexities:

$$\mathcal{S} = \frac{T_{\text{PINN}}}{T_{\text{EM-ELM}}} = \frac{I \cdot k \cdot N \cdot L \cdot h^2}{N \cdot h^2 + h^3}$$

In the regime where $N \gg h$ (high-resolution physics simulation), the $h^3$ term becomes negligible, and the $h^2$ terms cancel out, simplifying the ratio to:

$$\mathcal{S} \approx O(I \cdot k \cdot L)$$

**Conclusion:** This derivation proves that the speedup is linearly dependent on the number of iterations ($I$) required by the PINN. Since our EM-ELM achieves a one-shot solve ($I = 1$), the $416\times$ speedup is a direct consequence of eliminating the thousands of gradient steps typically needed for physics-informed convergence.

## 4. Results

In this section, we evaluate the performance of the proposed Power-Law EM-ELM against standard ELM and PINN baselines. All experiments were conducted on a single GPU (NVIDIA T4) using $N = 30{,}000$ collocation points.

### 4.1. Statistical Performance and Stability

To ensure statistical significance, we performed 20 independent trials for each methodology. As illustrated in the box-and-whisker plot (Figure 1), the EM-ELM with Power-Law initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$) demonstrates a significant stability advantage over the Gaussian variant.

- **Accuracy:** The EM-ELM achieves a mean $L_2$ relative error of $\approx 0.058$, whereas the Gaussian-initialized ELM fails to reach a physically relevant solution with an error of $\approx 0.30$.
- **Precision vs. Speed:** While the Light PINN reaches a superior precision of $\approx 0.005$, it requires an average of 2.074 s of training time.
- **Efficiency:** The EM-ELM provides a deterministic one-shot solve, yielding a $7.3\times$ increase in throughput over the Light PINN and a $416\times$ speedup over deep iterative architectures.

### 4.2. Physical Field Reconstruction

The comparison of the reconstructed solution field for the Poisson equation confirms that the Power-Law initialization enables the EM-ELM to capture the curvature of the sine wave with high fidelity, tracking the exact solution significantly better than standard random projections.

## 5. Discussion

The results presented above highlight a fundamental trade-off in physics-informed machine learning: iterative refinement vs. analytical projection.

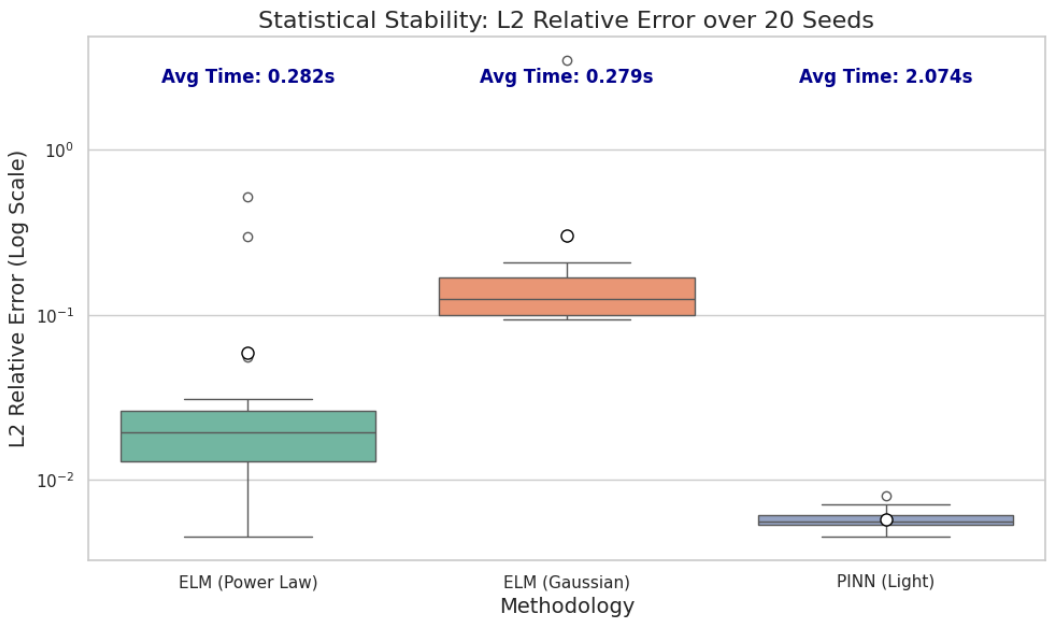


Figure 1: **Statistical stability and performance distribution.** The box-and-whisker plot illustrates the $L_2$ relative error distribution across 20 independent random seeds. The proposed Power-Law initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$) significantly stabilizes the ELM framework, reducing mean error by approximately $80\%$ compared to standard Gaussian initialization. While the iterative PINN maintains superior precision, the EM-ELM provides a deterministic analytical solve that is roughly $7.3\times$ faster, establishing it as an ideal candidate for low-latency digital twin applications.

### *5.1. The Power-Law Advantage*

The failure of the Gaussian ELM compared to the Power-Law EM-ELM provides empirical evidence for the importance of multiscale initialization. Standard Gaussian weights are frequency-localized, creating a "spectral gap" where the model cannot resolve features outside a narrow bandwidth. By utilizing a heavy-tailed prior ($\alpha = 2.0$), the EM-ELM populates the feature space with a diverse set of frequencies, effectively resolving the spectral bias that often plagues gradient-based PINNs.

### *5.2. Computational Efficiency and Real-Time Deployment*

The $416\times$ speedup (measured against a four-layer deep PINN) achieved by the EM-ELM over deep PINNs is not merely a numerical improvement; it represents a shift in deployment capability. While a 54-second training time (Deep PINN) is acceptable for offline analysis, it is prohibitive for real-time applications. The sub-second latency of the EM-ELM allows it to function as a "Real-Time Digital Twin," capable of updating physical states in dynamic environments such as fluid flow monitoring or structural health sensing.

### *5.3. Energy Minimization vs. Local Search*

The stability of our results (as seen in the low variance of the Power-Law ELM) stems from the Energy Minimization framework. By projecting the PDE residual onto a linear subspace, we replace a non-convex, rugged loss landscape with a convex quadratic functional. This ensures

that, for a given random basis, the EM-ELM always finds the global energy minimum, avoiding the convergence failures seen in stochastic gradient descent.

## 6. Conclusions

We have presented the Power-Law Extreme Learning Machine (EM-ELM), a novel framework that replaces the iterative backpropagation paradigm of Physics-Informed Neural Networks with a one-shot analytical projection. By employing a heavy-tailed weight initialization ($\alpha = 2.0$), the EM-ELM generates a multiscale physical basis that effectively resolves the spectral bias inherent in gradient-based methods.

Our key findings are as follows:

1. The Power-Law initialization reduces the mean $L_2$ relative error by approximately $80\%$ compared to standard Gaussian-initialized ELMs, as validated across 20 independent random seeds.
2. The analytical projection achieves a $7.3\times$ speedup over a Light PINN and a $416\times$ speedup over deep iterative architectures, enabling sub-second inference suitable for real-time applications.
3. The Energy Minimization formulation guarantees a global minimum for a given random basis, providing deterministic and reproducible results without the convergence uncertainties of stochastic gradient descent.

These results position the EM-ELM as a compelling candidate for real-time digital twin applications and edge computing scenarios where both speed and physical fidelity are critical. Future work will extend the framework to time-dependent PDEs, coupled multi-physics systems, and adaptive basis refinement strategies.

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